

# Berkeley: introduction

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January 8, 2004



# Ideas

- Locke: an idea is ‘whatsoever is the object of the understanding when a man thinks’
  - Where ‘thinking’ covers all kinds of conscious mental activity, including perception.
  - *Sensations*: the (especially vivid) ideas whose presence to the mind is involved in sensory experiences.
- Different people have different ideas (at least when they are having dissimilar experiences).



# Hume's argument from illusion

When we press one eye with a finger, we will immediately perceive all the objects to become double, and one half of them to be remov'd from their common and natural position. But as we do not attribute a continu'd existence to both these perceptions, and as they are both of the same nature, we clearly perceive, that all our perceptions are dependent on our organs, and the disposition of our nerves and animal spirits. This opinion is confirm'd by the seeming encrease and diminution of objects, according to their distance; by the apparent alterations in their figure; by the changes in their colour and other qualities from our sickness and distempers; and by an infinite number of other experiments of the same kind.... (Hume, *A Treatise of Human Nature* (1739), p. 211)



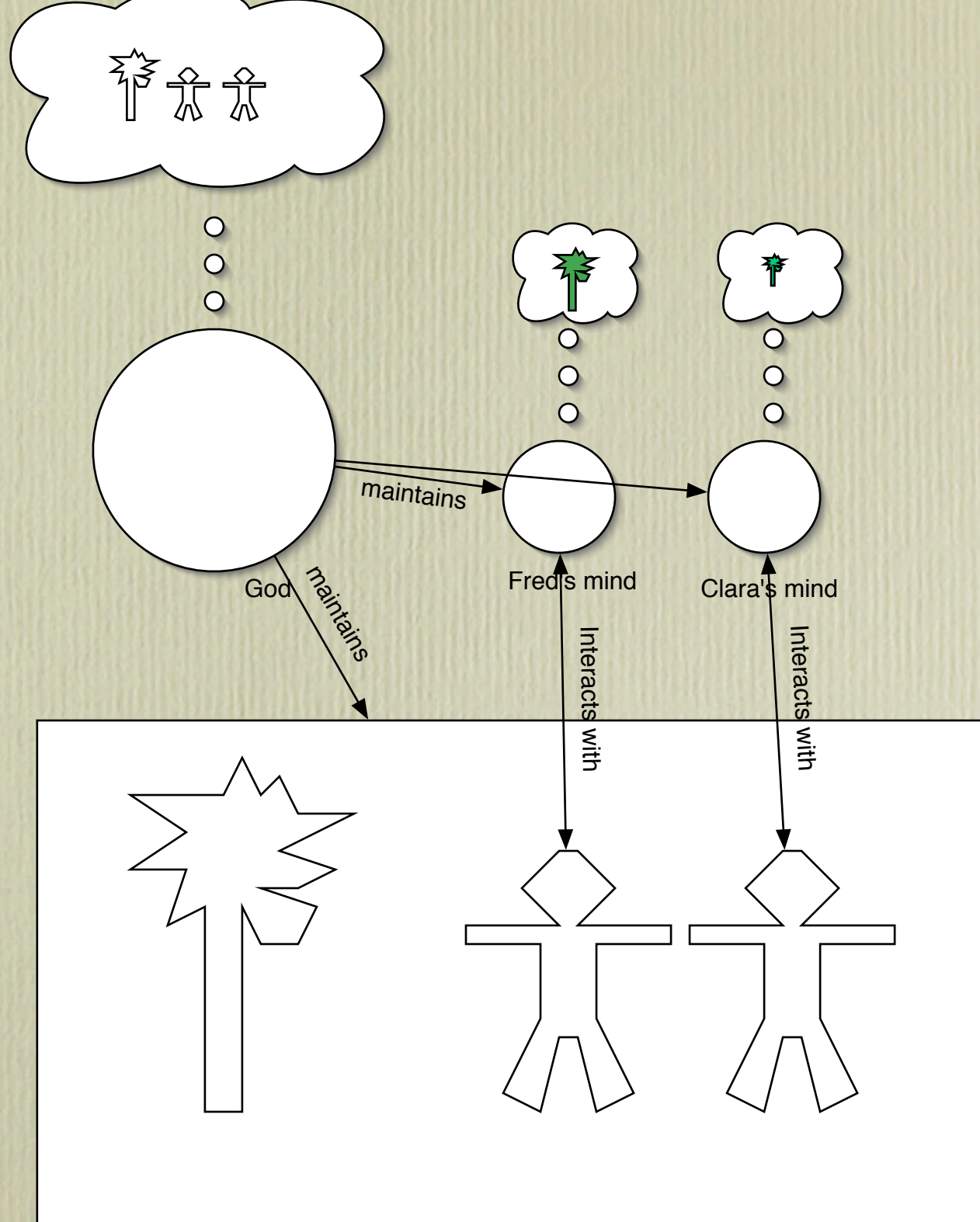
# The substance-dualist picture (Descartes)

- According to dualism, there are two basic kinds of individual things (= ‘substances’ in the philosophical sense): *material objects* and *minds*.
  - Material objects are fully characterised by basic properties needed for physics = *primary qualities*.
    - The mechanical philosophy.
  - In Descartes’ system of physics, this means that the complete story about the material world is given by specifying the *geometric* properties and relations of each material object over time.



- There's no necessary connection between any given pattern of physical facts and any given pattern of mental facts.
- God freely establishes laws which say how the properties of certain material objects will affect and be affected by the properties of certain minds.
  - Descartes' speculation about the pineal gland.
- God also keeps the material world in existence and keeps the laws of physics in operation.







# Secondary qualities

- If you want to describe someone's *ideas*, you'll need a lot more than geometric vocabulary.
- You'll also have to talk a lot about properties that have no role at all in physics: colours, sounds, smells, tastes and tactile characteristics — the *secondary qualities*.
- Secondary qualities are in some sense not objective in the way that primary qualities are.



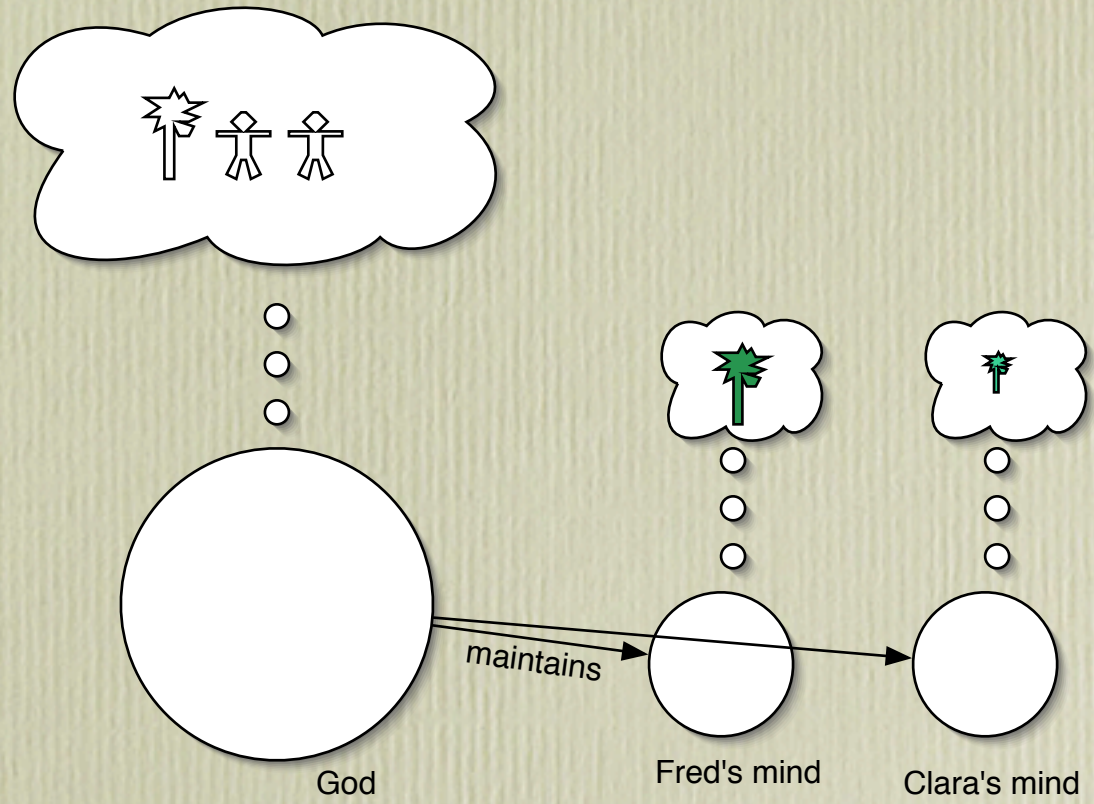
- Berkeley argues that secondary qualities are not qualities of material objects at all, but instead qualities of ideas (sensations).
  - Berkeley seems to think that this opinion is held by most contemporary philosophers.
  - But in fact many philosophers, including Descartes, Locke and Boyle, held a different theory, according to which colours are *dispositions* to produce sensations of a certain kind, which physical objects really do have (in virtue of their primary qualities).



# Berkeley's idealism

- Why are we supposed to believe in the material world? Presumably because it's needed to explain why we have the ideas (and in particular the sensations) that we have.
- But (according to the standard Cartesian view), God is needed both to explain why the material world is the way it is, and to explain why this leads to our having the ideas that we have.
- Why not simplify matters by dropping the material world out of the picture entirely?







# Reading for next week

- Berkeley, *Three Dialogues*, up to the last full paragraph on p. 78 [191-192]